

# AI Literacy for Everyone: Core Benefits for Underserved and Justice-Impacted Communities

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*A program brief drawn from the companion research papers “The Impact of AI on Society and the Economic Benefits for the Future Workforce” (Gladney, 2026)*

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## Why this population, and why now

The research is unambiguous on one point: **the people with the least formal education and the most barriers to employment have the most to gain from AI literacy — and the most to lose without it.**

- The jobs most accessible to workers without degrees or with employment gaps — data entry (–25.9%), word processing (–36.1%), switchboard/routine clerical work (–26.3%), cashiering (–9.9%) — are exactly the jobs declining fastest (U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2024–34 projections).
- At the same time, the strongest scientific result in the field runs in their favor: in the landmark NBER study of 5,172 workers, AI assistance raised productivity **34% for novice and lower-skilled workers versus 14% overall** — the least experienced gained the most (Brynjolfsson, Li & Raymond, 2023). Stanford task-simplification research projects lower-skilled workers could earn **15–45% more over a lifetime** in an AI-integrated economy, compressing the wage gap.
- AI literacy is the trigger for that gain. It requires no degree, no fees for entry-level tools, and no fixed schedule — only access, guidance, and practice.

**AI is the rare workforce technology that is easiest to learn for the people who need it most: it speaks plain language, it is patient, it is free at the entry level, and it works on a smartphone or a library computer.**

## The six core benefits

### 1. The lowest-cost job skill with the highest measured return

Jobs requiring AI skills pay a **62% wage premium** (PwC, 2026) — and the skill can be learned on free tools, in weeks not years, with no tuition, no commute, and no prerequisite credentials. No other workforce intervention offers this ratio of cost to return.

## 2. Skills-based hiring opens doors that credentials and background checks used to close

Degree requirements are falling fastest in AI-augmented jobs; **66% of business leaders say they would not hire someone without AI skills, and 71% would choose a less-experienced candidate with AI skills over a more-experienced one without** (Microsoft/LinkedIn). For returning citizens and adults without degrees, this is the labor market saying: *what you can demonstrate now matters more than your paper history*. Demonstrable AI fluency is a credential a student can build in a single program cycle.

## 3. AI is a personal advocate for people navigating complex systems

The same skills that make someone employable also help them stabilize their life — often the prerequisite to employment:

- **Homelessness and housing:** drafting housing applications, benefits paperwork (SNAP, Medicaid, SSI), and appeal letters; finding shelters and services; managing a job search from a phone without a fixed address or printer.
- **Legal and reentry:** understanding expungement and record-sealing eligibility in plain language, preparing court and licensing paperwork, drafting honest disclosure statements for employers, and identifying second-chance employers. (Taught alongside the critical-literacy rule: *AI output is a starting draft to verify — never legal advice.*)
- **Healthcare:** preparing questions for appointments, understanding diagnoses, medications, and insurance letters, and finding low-cost care — while learning to verify information and protect personal health data.
- **Education gaps:** an endlessly patient, judgment-free tutor for GED preparation, English learning, reading support, and digital basics — private, self-paced, and free.

## 4. Immediate job-search power

The first week of an AI-literacy class can produce material results: a professional resume and tailored cover letters, practice interviews with feedback, plain-language decoding of job postings, and application tracking — capabilities that typically cost hundreds of dollars through resume services, delivered by a free tool the student controls. For people re-entering the workforce after incarceration, illness, or homelessness, AI collapses the distance between “starting over” and “presenting professionally.”

## 5. Real pathways into growing work — not just tech jobs

The future-of-work data shows growth in accessible occupations: care work, delivery, agriculture, skilled trades, and education support are among the largest-growth categories through 2030 (WEF),

and every one of them is becoming AI-augmented — scheduling, dispatch, documentation, customer communication. AI literacy makes a candidate more valuable in the jobs they can get today, while “seniorised” entry-level roles (+35% since 2019) reward exactly what training can build: judgment plus AI leverage. Public money exists to fund this now: **WIOA funds are explicitly authorized for AI literacy** for youth, adult, and dislocated-worker programs, alongside the Department of Labor’s AI Literacy Framework and expanding registered apprenticeships.

## 6. Protection from a widening divide

Without intervention, AI will widen inequality: those already connected learn it at work and school (4 in 5 students already use it), while disconnected adults fall further behind — in jobs, in access to increasingly AI-mediated government and health services, and in vulnerability to AI-powered scams and misinformation, which disproportionately target vulnerable people. Teaching critical AI literacy — how to verify outputs, spot manipulation, and protect personal data — is consumer protection and digital citizenship, not just job training.

## The equity argument in one paragraph

AI’s benefits are real but not self-distributing: investment is concentrated, adoption is concentrated, and the entry-level rung is under pressure. The research shows the largest measured productivity gains flow to the least experienced workers, wage-gap compression is plausible, and hiring is shifting from credentials to demonstrable skills — but **only for people who are taught**. AI literacy for underserved communities is therefore not charity and not remedial education. It is the highest-leverage workforce investment available: the population with the greatest documented upside, learning the lowest-cost skill with the highest measured wage return, funded by mechanisms (WIOA, apprenticeships, library and community-college systems) that already exist.

## Program design principles (from the research)

1. **Meet learners where they are:** smartphone-first, library and shelter partnerships, no assumed laptop, childcare-aware scheduling, materials at accessible reading levels and in multiple languages.
2. **Teach the four literacies together** (UNESCO-aligned): *functional* (what AI is), *practical* (using it for work and life), *critical* (verifying, spotting bias and scams), *ethical* (privacy, honesty with employers).
3. **Lead with life wins, then job wins:** benefits letters and resumes in week one build the trust and momentum that carry learners through the workforce curriculum.

4. **Measure like a program:** apply the KSA → OKR → KPI framework — certification rates, weekly active use, job placement, wage progression of completers — so funders see outcomes, not attendance.
  5. **Pair with second-chance employer partnerships:** the 71% preference for AI-skilled candidates is the lever; a demonstration portfolio (real prompts, real work products) is the graduate's new credential.
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## Key sources

Brynjolfsson, Li & Raymond (NBER, 2023) · Stanford HAI AI Index 2025 & 2026 · PwC Global AI Jobs Barometer 2025 & 2026 · WEF Future of Jobs Report 2025 · Microsoft & LinkedIn Work Trend Index 2024 · U.S. BLS Occupational Projections 2024–34 · U.S. DOL AI Literacy guidance & WIOA Training and Employment Notice 07-25 · UNESCO AI Competency Frameworks (2024) · Executive Order 14277 on AI Education (2025). Full citations in the companion research paper.